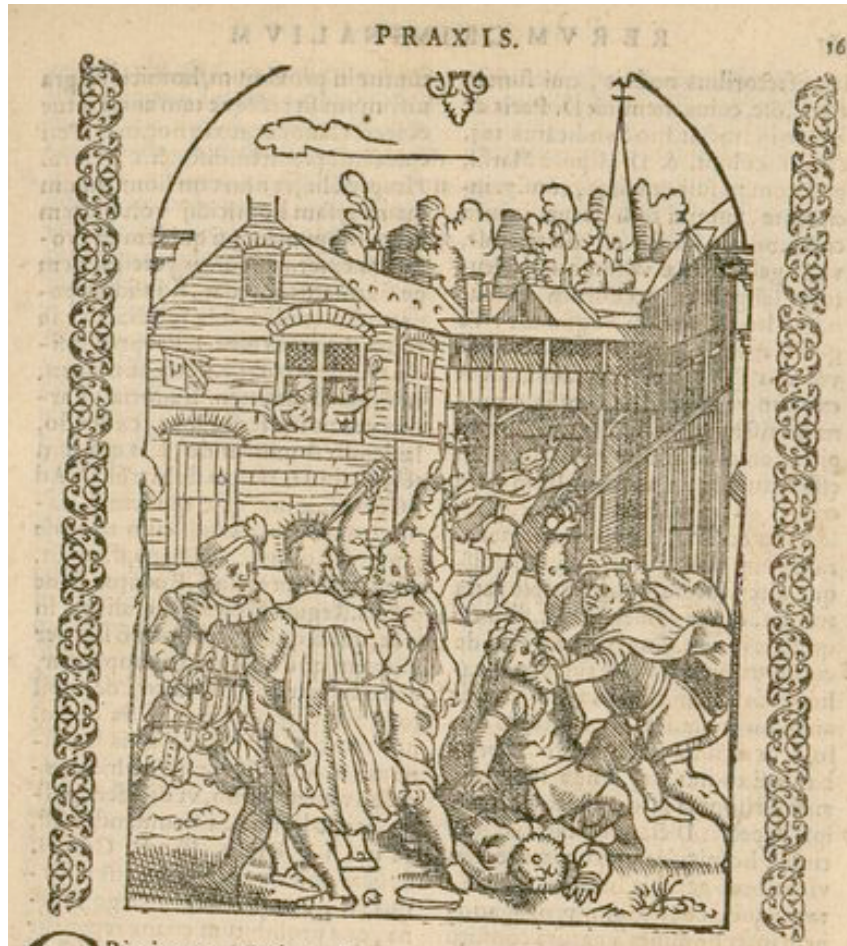


EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 10: Jews and Violence in the Early Modern Period



Jodocus Damhouder, *Praxis Rerum Criminalium*, 1562, p. 167

University of Maryland, College Park, MD, August, 18-20, 2013

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Rome, 1571: a corpse and a murder investigation in the ghetto

Serena Di Nepi, Sapienza – Università di Roma

Introduction

The story of Sabato del Corsetto tells about violence in the Roman ghetto in the second half of Sixteenth Century. It concerns many issues related to violence: family violence; verbal violence; physical violence; violence among women; violence arisen both for economic and personal reasons and even attempt made by the Jewish community to manage violence and violent people.

Criminal Sources in Early Modern Rome:

The story is developed by three different primary sources, all written by the offices of the Criminal Court of Papal Rome at the end of 1571 (august 1571 – February 1572). The first two concern two different trials while the last one comes from the register of Investigations made by the same Court. In Early Modern Justice, real trials were final steps of a longer proceeding beginning in various ways included anonymous denunciation and police investigation. People could be imprisoned and questioned about a crime out of a trial, in a preliminary phase called *Costituti*, which means “Questions on a crime”. Only some of these examinations resulted in judicial proceedings in a court: we have dozens of registers of *Costituti* for any year and just few trials related to these. During the examination, questions were in Latin and answers in ancient Italian. Sentences represented another problem for the historians: even if all trials reached an end, just a few parts of these conclusions were recorded as single sentence. The most of them were just noted in registers of general administrative acts made by the same Offices (called *Registrazioni d’atti*), among many other issues, and it’s necessary to look carefully pages and pages to discover what happened to the indicted.

The trial against Sabato (1571): a violent Jewish Society

Sabato turned himself to the court on October 15, 1571 to clarify his non-involvement in the death of Rubbino Rossetto, an old rabbi, whose corpse

was found in the ghetto, early in the morning on an unprecised day at the beginning of August 1571. Sabato was immediately suspected of the murder for two main reasons. On one hand, many witnesses attested he was involved in a violent quarrel just the night before and – as they said - it was possible that he deathly hit the old rabbi when he run furiously after another Jew, Sciolomon Siciliano. On the other hand, he was really unpopular and his enemies regarded to this brawl as an opportunity to take revenge on him. As he told to the court, in the last years he had argued with other Jews on job questions, which could be solved only thanks to some external interference. Sabato began to pick up dead horses as a certain Angelo Funaro previously did. So Angelo assaulted him and Sabato went to the Vicario to denounce Angelo. At the moment of this trial, Sabato and Angelo were partners in a company: this means that by anyway, probably after a private agreement ordered by Jewish arbiters, Angelo e Sabato were forced to put away their problems and work together. Of course, Angelo wasn't happy of this solution.

During his examination, Sabato tried to depict himself as a good guy but his precedents didn't help him to fulfill the task. Not only he had been imprisoned many times formerly but he had also disappeared for months at the beginning of this investigation. His narrative was centered on the representation of a victim: he had been ill, Jewish people are “sad” (bad people), he was poor, he had no enemies but a lot of people hate him (included the famous Jewish notary Pompeo del Borgo). Nonetheless, his violent attitude emerged from his own words and for this he attempted to dilute his behavior in a general violent contest, where a women brawl was usual as a job fight, a stabbing and threatening ?someone with a gun. There weren't evidences against Sabato apart from the ghetto gossip. He confirmed his deposition even under torture and he was freed on October 30.

A Jewish gang: social and psychological violence in the ghetto

Just few months later, on February, Sabato was again in the same prison, this time to witness against a group of Jews. His own trial concerned physical violence while this second action reported on psychological and social violence. It was a case of bullying, where unconscious Jews used Christian institution to make money in prejudice of other Jews. If the murder investigation was the opportunity for some of elder Sabato's enemies to punish him after job questions, this one was his occasion to get even. It was

the custody of a young man, found in a neophyte's home out of the ghetto during the night, to let the investigation begin. Suddenly the "birri" (policemen) revealed an incredible story where, in order to forgive gambling debts, a Jewish gang was used to steal stuff in the home of the wealthy people of the ghetto on Shabbat evening. As the examinations went on, it was clear that the gang was the author of a growing number of malefactions, included the one on which Sabato vouched that concerned a racket on false witnesses.

As this second trial attested, interlaced interests and networks crossed the ghetto and it was not easy to survive among these. Ancient aversions, rudeness, unfairness, fierce competition in a so limited job market were all element of daily life for Jewish people in Rome. They were used to crash against other Jews for a huge number of reasons. The judicial adventures of Sabato del Corsetto reveal how frequent were both those violent brawls and the consequent imprisonment. Just to speak on his past, Sabato was involved at least in four quarrels (that included a death, a stabbing and a gun shot) and he was captured four times (illegal trade, false witnesses etc...). It's hard to live together, sharing little spaces and concurring for the same (few works). This condition was a perfect habitat for daily violence, as the story of Sabbato confirms.

Remaining Jews in Counter Reformation Rome

In Counter-Reformation Rome, there was an easy way to escape from this ugly condition and it was, of course, conversion to Christianity.

It's important to remember that both these trials could have ended with a baptism. Sabato stayed out of the ghetto for days after the discovery of Rubino's corpse. The *birri* looked for him in the Jewish quarter unsuccessfully until he decided to present to the judges. During all this time, he remained in Rome, probably in some Christian or neophyte's home. He recalled this period during his examination as a proof of his innocence: «I told the truth and so God helped me because I didn't sin; If I was guilty, I should flew away to Turkey or to some other places » [*Io ho detto la verita et cosi Dio mi aiuto come non ho peccato et se io fossi stato me ne saria andato in Turchia o in qualche altro loco*]. While Sabato thought to Ottoman Turkey as a safer place, it should be underlined that he never referred to the House of Catechumens, which represented a closer and easier solution to all his problems. The same was for the Jews of the gang, despite

their dangerous connections with neophytes. The leaders were sentenced to exile and nobody choose to convert even in this case.

The story of Sabato offers two clues to reflect on the Roman Jews resistance to conversion. As he said, his job quarrel with Angelo Funaro (against whom he vouched in the second trial) was resolved in the ghetto: «Now I'm in their company for the next two years and we have to be in company». This short sentence means that the two parts came to an agreement after the denunciation to the Vicario and that this agreement was signed inside the Jewish society (otherwise Sabato should have told to the judges the name of the Christian notary that wrote the act as usual in such cases). They weren't friends but they had to keep calm and the Jewish institutions worked to establish a kind of peace inside the ghetto.

The memorandum of the discovery of money in Rubino's home tells something more on this politic. It was written few days after the death, while Sabato was lost out of the ghetto and police was still investigating on the murder. The note doesn't mention these topics. It concerns tension between the representatives of *Gemilut Hasadim* and Rubino's heirs, at the beginning on the possibility to find something in the home, than on the right division of the treasure. At least, it refers to the way to diffuse this tension, entrusting the management of the money to an important Jewish banker as Angelo di Capua and informing Christian authority about the fact only after its peaceful solution.

Roman society was violent and Jews were as violent as Christians. Brawls blew up frequently and involved Jews both in contrast with other Jews and against Christians. We had many *Costituti* on fights in Roman market places where some Jews played a role, but this isn't our point. Violence inside the ghetto walls was more dangerous for the Jewish community that the other one, just under the eye of Christian Courts. Jewish society tried to govern itself despite its inner violence, using any tool to run the people of the ghetto, from internal agreement to the clever use of Christian juridical system. Sometimes it succeeded, sometimes it failed but it's important to investigate the ways they used to manage themselves in the long ghetto era.

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Rome, 1571: a body and a murder investigation in the ghetto

Serena Di Nepi, Sapienza – Università di Roma

Rome, Archivio di Stato di Roma, *Tribunale Criminale del Governatore, Processi*, registro 140, case 8, cc. 422r/457r*

*In the Court of the Most Reverend Governor of Rome
Trial for alleged murder in Rome against the Jew Sabato son of Angelo del Corsetto. Master Johannes Paulus Majnus, chancellor and notary*

*In God's Name, Amen.
October 15, 1571*

Interrogated in person in Rome in Tor di Nona [the municipal] prison, in the court of His Excellency Master Bernardino Coto lieutenant and magistrate, and in my presence mister Vincentio Berti substitute.

Sabato son of Angelo de Piperno Jew, to whom I administered the oath to tell the truth. He gave his oath before me "tacto calamo," that is, in the Jewish manner.

Questioned about how he came to the prison, whether he was arrested or came of his own will.

He answered: I'm here in prison and I presented myself spontaneously because someone told me that one of the nephews (I don't remember his name) of Rubino Roscietto accused me of his death; I wanted to come earlier but I was ill.

Questioned about the reason for which, according to him, he has been charged about the deceased Rubino Roscetto.

He answered: It was more or less two months ago that one evening – at nearly the 24th hour of the night – my wife told me that my sister Chiara had been dragged by her hair by the sister of the wife of Sciolomon, whose

* Latin in the original appears here in italics; Italian is presented in Roman characters. I'd like to thank Bernard Cooperman for his carefully revision of my English translations.

father was Sicilian. When I arrived, I knew that my sister went to the court to report this scuffle and when I entered, I said aloud: "May my sister be killed [if she] should not be dragged by her hair!" Just at that moment Sciolomon walked by and said "Be careful! My sister-in-law isn't a woman to be taken by hair!" I replied: "Nor is my sister such a woman!" And so he said: "Shut up!" One word led to another and Sciolomon hit me on my shoulder and escaped and so I ran after him, but my wife stopped me. It was said that I had bumped into Rubbino Roschetto as I ran after Sciolomon, but I could not reach him! In the middle of the street I punched my wife who was trying to stop me, and this made a little blood come out of her mouth, and then I told her to be quiet. I think that's why people think I hit Rubin Roscietti.

Questioned as to whether he carried any weapon as he ran after Sciolomon.

He answered: That evening as I ran after Salomon I had no weapon of any sort; neither stones nor sticks. I did not think of carrying weapons and I had only a fruit that I was eating at the moment.

Questioned as to whether he knew the said Rubino Roscietto, and how.

He answered: Of course, I knew Rubino Roscietto who was old and went around teaching the little kids.

Questioned about the place where he stopped running after Solomon and on whether he knew where Rubino Roscietto had been injured.

He answered: That evening I ran after Solomon until Moise Pellegrino's home, where my wife grabbed me; I threw her on the ground, I hit her and some women picked her up. Then I went home. I understood that someone had bumped into Rubin Roscietto next to the river gates.

Questioned about his dinner on that evening with his wife.

He answered: That evening – when my wife stopped me – I came back home for dinner and I slept there.

Questioned as to whether he ate alone or with others that night, and with whom.

He answered: That evening I dined with my father, my sister and my wife.

Questioned whether he learned that night what happened to Rubino Rossetto.

He answered: The [next] morning after I heard that Rubino Roschetto was dead I was waiting at the gate to Piazza Giudea to go with some other fellows to collect dead animals around Rome; while I was waiting someone advised me to run away because the police were at my house. Even my father told me to go away for some days, so I did for the next eight days. Then I fell ill with a fever, toothache and *zincone*. During that period I was here and there and did the best I could, but I was never out of Rome.

Questioned why he did not Sciolomon again after he threw his wife to the ground.

He answered: Solomon was as far away as twice this room (and he indicates the visiting room of the prison); he ran as fast as a goat; so, I did not catch him again and I went to my home.

Questioned where he began to run after Solomon and how far this place was from the other where he claims his wife stopped him.

He answered: That evening I started to run from my home until, as I said, that of Moise son of Pellegrino. That is more or less twice [the size] of this room from my house.

Questioned about how far the place where he claims he was held by his wife to the spot where he understood the late Rubino Rosetto died).

He answered: The distance between the place where my wife stopped me that night and the other where Rubino Rosetto felt down was nearly twice this room.

Questioned if he knew or heard that there was a murder investigation into Rubino Rossetto's death.

He answered: I don't know and I didn't hear that witnesses have been interrogated on this death.

Questioned if he had any enemy and who they are.

He answered: As far as I know I have neither enemies nor ill-wishers. Once I was arrested, and the court interrogated me about whether I traveled to Florence and I paid 4 scudi; another time – maybe 15 days before Rubino Rosetto's death – I was arrested again by magister Valerio, who asked me if I knew a tailor and I answered that I didn't; eight or nine years ago, I was arrested by Your Lordship together with my father and my brother-in-law to be questioned about some wheat that somebody said we bought.

Questioned if he knew Pompeo del Borgo and why.

He answered: Of course, I know Pompeo the Jew for a long time, because I know all the Jews.

Questioned if he knows that some Jews were arrested for Rubino Rosetto's death and who they are.

He answered: My father told me that some men and women were arrested for Rubin Rosetto's death but he didn't tell me who.

Questioned if Pompeo the Jew was a friend of his and what opinion he held and holds of him.

He answered: When I was arrested eight or nine years ago by Your Lordship, he interrogated me and had me jailed because he is relative of a certain Angelo – who was incarcerated for the same wheat. I've nothing to do with him, and I reported about Pompeo the truth of what he did.

Asked to explain what opinion he held and holds of Pompeo, and whether he considers him a man of bad or good condition and reputation.

He answered: I think that all the Jews are sad people, with the exception of my father but it's not for me to say this.

Questioned if he was used to carrying any kind of weapon (iron, lead or marble)

He answered: If you discover that I carry any cudgel (lead or marble), you must punish me more than I deserve.

Questioned if he knew that the deceased Rubino Roscietto was injured when he died and in which part of the body and by whom.

He answered: I don't know and I never knew that Rubin Roscietto had any injury when he died.

Questioned where Rubino Rossetto's death was caused.

He answered: I don't know and I never knew what caused his death; I heard that Robin Roscetti it was two or three hours till he died, that he was found on the ground next to the river gate.

c. 426 r.

October, 19th 1571

Interrogated in person in Tor di Nona, Rome's municipal prison, in the court of His Excellence Master Bernardino Coto lieutenant and magistrate and in my presence, Master Vincentio Berti substitute.

Sabato son of Angelo del Corsetto Jew, as above, to whom I administered the oath to tell the truth. He gave his oath before me "tacto calamo," that is, in the Jewish manner.

Asked if he wanted to say something more on what he had said in his previous deposition.

He answered: No, I don't need to say anything else because what I said in my previous deposition was totally correct.

Questioned if in the past he had a row with other Jews during which he could have injured someone or be injured by someone else.

He answered: it is possible that I had a quarrel with other Jews but now I do not remember, except maybe something happened when I was very young.

Questioned if he knew Angelo son of Giuseppe Funari and when and why they dealt together.

He answered: Of course, I know Angelo Funaro and I dealt with him. It was about four or five months ago and I was standing at the door to my house,

maybe at one in the night, and he suddenly assaulted me with a pistol, he hit me, I didn't escape but I tried to save myself and I was secretly hidden when he searched that room (*and he indicates the visiting room*); then he was saved in the house of Zozo, another Jew, next to the gate.

Questioned why Angelo Funaro assaulted him with that gun.

He answered: He assaulted me because I began to engage in the same profession as he – that is with animal corpses. Until that time, he was the only one who did that; he wanted to buy the animals for nothing.

Once I undertook the same business he thought he wouldn't be able to get the animals for that price as he wished. For this reason, he began to hunt me down and say that he wanted to kill me or beat me because he and his fellows were four people, all ready to chase me. So, I went by the Vicar to accuse them, they were questioned and shortly after he assaulted me. Prior to those events, I had never had anything to deal with him, except for this job and now I'm in their company for the next two years and we have to be in company.

Questioned if he drew a gun against Angelo in order to beat him with that weapon.

He answered: You'll never find that I draw a gun against someone.

Questioned if he said the truth concerning Rubino the Jew.

He answered: I did tell [the truth] and I maintain what I said for the next 100 years. The truth is that I did not run up to the place where he fell down and I did not otherwise see him on the ground.

[The next days, the court questioned some other people, including the Jewish notary Pompeo Del Borgo]

October 22, 1571

Sabato son of Angelo del Corsetto Jew

Sabato was questioned if there were other people that could see his wife stopped him from running after Solomon.

He answered: That evening, as I ran after Solomon and my wife stopped me, there was Patello the Jew who also held me. He held me again when I stopped in front of the door of Moise son of Pellegrino but I'm sure that he won't say about this because he is one of Solomon's cousins and they are like two brothers and so I didn't mention about his presence.

Questioned if he had an arm raised as he ran after Solomon and if it was the right or the left.

He answered: That evening, as I ran after Solomon, I had neither right arm nor left one raised.

Questioned if he knows the Jew Marchisian aka Marchisianella had been quoted by Pompeo during his deposition.

He answered: I know a Jewish woman called Marchisianella. She is an enemy of mine because Dattilo, her brother, cut one arm of my cousin Ventura. I reported them and they were sent to galley.

[In the next days, the court confronted Marchisianella and Sabato. Both confirmed their previous depositions. Sabato was put to torture but didn't change his story. Meanwhile another major trial was begun against the Jews triggered by Friday night burglaries involving a large group of individuals. Sabato also gave testimony in this matter. Though we don't have the final sentence, there is the brief note in Register 59 of the "Registrazioni d'atti" of this court dated October 30th, 1571: "Pro Sabato del Corsetto hebreo" (In favor of Sabato del Corsetto Jew). Thus on that day Sabato was freed.]

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1) Roma, Archivio di Stato di Roma, *Tribunale Criminale del Governatore, Processi*, registro 140, case 8, cc. 422r/457r

*Reverendissimo Almae Urbis Gubernatore
Romana Praesunti Homicidi
Pro Fisco contra Sabatum Angeli del Corsetto Hebreum
Domino Johannes Paulus Majnus cancellarius et notarius*

*In Dei Nomine Amen
Die 15 Mensis Octobris 1571*

*Constitutus personaliter Rome in carceribus cittadini Turris None coram V. S. I. domino Bernardino Coto locumtenentem magistratoque et in presentia mei assistente domino Vincentio Berti substituti.
Sabatus filius Angeli de Piperno Hebreus cui delatum fuit iuramentum veritatem dicentem et per eum iurato tacto calamo more Hebreorum fuit per me dictum.*

Interrogatus quomodo ipse Corsetto reperiatur huic in carceribus an fuit captus vel sponte comparvit ut ex qua circa.

Respondit: Io mi ritrovo qui prigionero che mi sono costituito da me et sono comparso perché mi estato apposto che io havevo dato a Robino Roscetti da un suo nipote che non mi ricorda il nome che io volevo comparire prima ma stavo ammalato.

Interrogatus an (scilicet) ad vult quomodo ipse Corsetto imputabitur per processum dictum quondam Rubinum Rosettum.

R: Una sera che era così l'ule 24 hora che possono essere fino à doi mesi poco piu e poco meno mi fu detto da mia mogliera che mia sorella chiamata, Chiara era stata scapigliata dalla sorella della moglie di Sciolomon che il padre era ciciliano che mia sorella era andata nella corte a darne querela et quando incorsi questo dissi “sia ammazzata mia sorella che doveva scapigliarsi lei” et in questo venne a passarsi questo Sciolomon et disse “Avverti come parli mia cognata non è donna da essere scapigliata” et io gli

replicai “manco mia sorella manco è donna da essere scapigliata” et lui mi disse “parla troncato” et dagli con mia parola et una altra detto Sciolomon mi dette un pugio che mi colse nella spalla et si mise a fugire et io li corsi direto et mia mogliera mi tenne et si diceva che io in quella sera haveva urtato Rubbino Roscietto mentre che correva direto al detto Sciolomon che io non potei giongere a mezza strada che io detti a mia moglie un pugio che li feci uscire un poco di sangue dalla bocca et li dissi che doveva tenere la parte et non me et in questo modo si pustapione che io habbi dato a Rubin Roscietti.

Interrogatus an ipse haberet aliquod gravis armorum et iuspium dum currisset dietro dictum Salomen et quod.

R: Quando io correvo in quella sera dietro a Salamon io non haveva arme di sorta nessuna ne sassi ne bastoni ne altro non mi occorreva portar armi che lui e un frutto che mel haveva mangiato.

Interrogatus an ipse Corsetto cogit dictum quondam Rubinum Rosettum et quomodo.

R: Si che io conoscevo questo Rubino Roscietto che era un vecchio di tempo et andava insegnando li putti

Interrogatus usque quo ipse Corsetto eo vesperi currisset dietro dictum Solomonem et dicat si lici audivit in quo loco dictus quondam Rubinum Rosettum fuerit vulneratus.

R: In quella sera io corsi dietro detto Solomone fino innanzi a casa di Moise di Pelegirino che li mi piglio mia moglie che io la butta in terra et li detti che certe donne poi la colsero et io me ne retornai et intesi che a detto Rubin Roscetto gli fu dato li accanto al porton di fiume.

Interrogatus quo ipse Corsetto pro dit asserit vedirit causpiam postquam sit fuit cenatus alicuius uxore.

R: In quella sera che fui tenuto da mia mogliera me tornai in casa mia a cena et dormii in casa mia

Interrogatus an solus vel associatus ea vesperi in cui domo convitus et cum quo.

R: In quella sera cenai in compagnia di mio padri e mia madre mia sorella et mia moglie.

Interrogatus an eo vesperi intellexerit quod dictus quondam Rubinus Rosettus fuerat (miservatus).

R: La matina io intesi che detto Rubin Roscetto era morto che io stavo li al porton di Piazza Giudea perche io vo pigliando le bestie morte per Roma con altri compagni et cosi aspettavo se mi veneva nessuno et cosi mi fu detto che la corte era in casa mia et cosi mi fu detto che io scanzassi che me lo disse anco mio padre et cosi fugitivo da otto dì et poi mi ammalai che mi venne la

febre et dipoi febre con dolori di denti et dipoi un zincone et in questo tempo sono stato hora di qua et hora di la che ho fatto il meglio che ho potuto ma non sono stato mai fora di Roma.

Interrogatus quam ipse Corsetto eo vesperi no fuerit insecutus dictum Solomonem postquam dicta eius uxor pro ut asserit fuisset loco proiecta in terra

R: Detto Salomone mi era lontano quanto doi volte questa stantia (*designas aulam visite carceratorum*) che lui correva come un caprio et per questo non li andai piu dietro che me ne andai a casa.

Interrogatus unde ipse Corsetto eo vesperi se movisset ad insequenda dictum Solomonem et que distantia esse possit a loco qui movit usque ad locum quo proprio ut asserit fuit tenutus ab eius uxore.

R: io mi mossi a corre dietro in quella sera a Salomon da casa mia fino a casa come ho detto di Moise di Pelegrino che è lontano da casa mia quanto due volte questa stantia poco più o poco meno.

Interrogatus que distantia esse possit a dicto loco in quo pro ut asserit fuit tenutus ab eius uxore usque ad locum in quo fuerit intellexerti fuit morietis dictus quondam Rubinus Rosettus.

R: dal detto loco dove fui tenuto da mia mogliera in quella sera fino al loco dove mi sepi che Rubin Roscietto casco ci po essere quanto doi volte questa stantia .

Interrogatus an sciat vel audit quod super vere dicti quondam Rubini Rossetti fuerint examinati aliqui testi et qui.

R: Io non so ne manco ho inteso dir che sopra la morte de Rubino Roschetto ci fussino esaminati alcuni testimoni.

Interrogatus an ipse Corsetto habeat aliquos malevolos et inimicos et quos.

R: Che io so ho non inimici ne malevoli io sono stato prigione una volta fui addimandato se io ero stato a Fiorenza et pagai 4 scudi et una volta circa 15 di prima che morissi Rubin Roscetti fui pregione di mastro Valerio che mi adimando per contro se io conoscevo un giupponaro che io ne conoscevo nessuno et una altra volta vira otto o nove anni fa fui pregione di V. S. insieme con mio padre et mio cognato per certo grano che dicevano che havevamo comprato.

Interrogatus an cogit et cogitat quondam Pompeum Hebrum et quomodo.

R: si che io conosco un Pompeo hebreo che tempo assai che lo conosco perche io conosco tutti li hebrei

Interrogatus an sciat seu dici audit que aliqui Hebrei fuerint carcerati ob mortem dicti quondam Rubini Rossetti et qui.

R: mio padre mi disse che per la morte di detto Rubin Roschetto furono prigionieri certi homini hebrei et certe donne ma non mi disse chi.

Interrogatus an dictus Pompeus Hebreus sit eius amicus et benevolus et pro qua persona habuerit et habeat.

R: Quando io fui prigione otto o nove anni fa di V. S. fece la examinatione et ci fece mettere prigione che era parente di uno Angelo che era prigione per conto del medesimo grano io non ho da far con lui non è pratica mia et io ho detto Pompeo per quello che è lo fa lui.

Interrogatus ut exprimat in qua opinione habuerit et habeat dictum Pompeum an pro homine mali conditionis et fame vel bone.

R: Io ho tutti li giudei per tristi eccetto mio padre che non sta a me di dirlo.

Interrogatus an ipse Corsetto fuerit et sit solitus deferre pilam ferri vel plumbi sei marmorea.

R: Se mori con verta mi provocava che habbi portata piombarola di piombo o di marmoro gastigatemi più di quello che io merito.

Interrogatus an intellexerit quod dictus quondam Rubinus Rossettus existerit vulneratus quando decessit et in qua parte et a quo.

R: io non so ne manco ho inteso che detto Rubino Roschetto haveva ferita nessuna quando morse.

Interrogatus an dici audit unde fuerit causata mors dicti quondam Rubinis Rossettis.

R: Io non ho ne manco ho inteso donde si causasse la morte di Robin Roscetti intesi che stette dui o tre hori a morire che fu trovato in terra la accanto il portone del fiume.

c. 426r. 19 ottobre 1571

Constitutus personaliter Rome in Carceribus Curie Turris Bernardino Coto locumtenentem magistratoque et in presentia mei assistente domino Vincentio Berti substituti.

Sabatus filius Angeli del Corsetto Hebreus de quo super cui delatum fuit iuramentum de veritate dicende et pro cum iurato tacto calamo more hebreorum fuit per me dominum.

Interrogatus an occurrat aliquod aliquid sibe dicere ultra ea que dixit in alio suo exame.

R: No che a me non occorre di dir altro oltre quello che io ho detto nel altra mia expositione che quello che ho detto nel altro mio expositione e bendetto.

Interrogatus an alia ipse Corsetto devenerit ad rixam cum aliquo hebreo in qua rixa ipse vulneraverit aliquem vel verumserit vulneratus.

R: Poteria essere che io fussi venuto a quistione con alcun giudio che io non me ne aricordassi adesso excepto che se non fussi quando ero putto piccolo che non fussi venuto a questione con qualchuno altro.

Interrogatus an ipse Corsetto cognoscat Angelum filium Iosephi Funarii et an eum ea cumquam aliquid de agere habuerit et quod.

R: Angiolo di Ioseph Funaro si in che lo cognosco et quel che ho avuto a fare con lui quisto che possono essere da quattro o cinque mesi che stando io sul uscio di casa mia che poteva essere circa la una di note lui mi assalto con una pistolessa et mi dette questa botta et non mi messi a fugire in ciò et cercassi di salvarmi et in segreto quando lui volse questa stantia (*desingnas stantiam visite*) et lui si salvò poi in casa di un altro ebreo acanto al portone che si chiama Zozo.

Interrogatus qua de eo dictus Angelum Funari regressus fuit ipsum Corsettum cum dicto pistolerio.

R: Lui mi assaltò perche mi ero messo a far larte che faceva lui delle bestie morte perche prima non ci era se non lui che la faceva et voleva comprar le bestie per niente e perche io mi misi a fare ancora detta arte che si pensava di non poter haver le bestie per quel prezzo come voleva per questo mi cominciò a bracciare con dire di volermi ammazzare o strapazzare che loro erano quattro che mi potevano andare ben dui di loro provassiro perche quando io landari a accusare al Vicario mi processarono di voler innanzi examinatione et de pe io che hebbi accusato lui mi assalto. Per prima io non havevo havuto a far cosa nessuna con lui se non per contro di questa arte come fu detto di sopra et edesso me hanno messo a parte del guadagno ma non posso havere in qua guadagno in cosa alcuna da loro et tra di noi ci e il contratto che per due anni non potemo spartire detta compagnia.

Interrogatus non ne verum est que ipsum Corsettum alias contra dictum Angelum proiecit quandam plumbarolam ad effectum illum percuotendi cum ea.

R: Non si trovara ne mai che io habbi mai puntata piombarola contro nissuno.

Interrogatus an se disposuerit veritare dicere circa factum Rubini Hebrei.

R: Io l'ho detto et quel che ho detto mantengo di qua a cento anni et la verita è che io non corsi fin la dove lui casco in terra ne manco lo viddi altrimenti in terra.

[*Vengono interrogati altri testimoni, incluso il notaio Pompeo del Borgo*]

Die 22 Octobris 1571

Sabatum Angeli del Corsetto hebreum

Interrogatus quo fuerunt eo quando eo vesperi currebat resti dictum Solomonem eum fuisset tenutus pro ut asserit ab eius uxore.

R: Quando io correvo dietro a Salomone in quella sera che io fui tenuto da mia moglie ci era presente Patello hebreo che lui ancora mi tenne et anco mi tenne quando io mi fermai innanti aluscio di Moise di Pellegrino ma detto Patello non lo vorra dire perche è cugino intrinseco di detto Solomon che son come fratelli et però non l'ho detto dal primo.

Interrogatus an ipse Corsetto quando eo vesperi currebat retro dictum Solomonem habuisset brachium elevatum et an dextrum vel sinistrum.

R: Quella sera mentre correvo dietro a detto Salomone non portavo ne il braccio dextro ne il braccio sinistro alzato

Interrogatus an cognoscat et cognoscati Marchiasiniam seu Marchiscianellam Hebream quam nominaverit presens Pompeus in eius examinatione quo iurit vidi dictam in presentia eius.

R: Io cognosco una donna che si chiama Marchisianella hebreo. Detta Marchisianella mi è inimica perche Dattilo suo fratello carnale taglio un braccio a mio fratello cugino chiamato Ventura che io procurai di farlo pigliare con certi altri et fu mandato in galea.

[In the next days, the court put in comparison Marchisianella and Sabato. Both confirmed their previous depositions; even if he was tortured, Sabato repeated his story. We have not the sentence but just a little note in the register 59 of the "Registrazioni d'atti" of this court, that simply says on October 30th, 1571 «Pro Sabato del Corsetto hebreo» (In favor of Sabato del Corsetto Jew). It means that Sabat was released on that day]

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Rome, 1571: a body and a murder investigation in the ghetto

Serena Di Nepi, Sapienza – Università di Roma

Roma, Archivio di Stato di Roma, *Tribunale Criminale del Governatore, Processi*, registro 140, case 11, cc. 869r-956v

[Trial for] various thefts and other excesses occurring in Rome.

The State v. Beniamino Guglielmo Minutelli; Vituccio son of Hysachini; Hysachum dello Strologo; Sabbatum alias Pattello; Angelo Gabrielis alis Taliaricetto; Cesarem bicarium Luceni; Angelus Moysis de Anguilaria; Deodatum son of Hysach; Abraam Cioppagialla; Leo son of Emanuel Pazzetium; Jacobumalis Consolomonis.

February 29, 1572

Interrogated in Rome in Tor di Nona [the municipal] prison, before [the Magistrate] Master Iohannis Maria Bugnolo lieutenant and assistant, and in my presence as notary.

Sabato son of Angelo del Corsetto Jew, to whom I administered the oath to tell the truth. He gave his oath before me “tacto calamo,” that is, in the Jewish manner.

Questioned if some days before his present incarceration he had been incarcerated anywhere else, and why.

He answered: I think about twenty days before I was imprisoned here I was in jail in Corte Savella for ten days, partly in the public prison and partly in the secret one. Magistrate Valerio questioned me and he asked if I knew certain people. I didn't know who they were. Magister Valerio thought it was a trivial matter (*bagatelle*) and so I was neither punished to be released nor did I pay anything, except for food and the prison [fee]. When I finally was out of the prison, my father told me that he gave 5 ducats to Angelo di Anguillara and to Angelo Barbaguano, because they said they had helped me to escape from the jail. But it was Angelo di Anguillara who spied on me in order to send me to that prison! So I understood everything. Indeed, just before I was jailed, Angelo told me that some of his relatives – horse

skinners by trade – promised him 10 scudi if he could send me to the prison; and they arranged this business because they didn't want that I “skin the horses” as I did.

Questioned if he knew anything else about Angelo of Anguillara. [The answer is underlined.]

He answered: If you'll question Giuseppe Funaro and Angelo Funaro, Zampanella and Mouse Ghian, you'll find that this Angelo sent a lot of people to jail, one even four times, and then he himself to get them free for a fee. He extracted a lot of money in this way, [though] to tell the truth they say good things about him.

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2) Roma, Archivio di Stato di Roma, *Tribunale Criminale del Governatore, Processi*, registro 140, case 11, cc. 869r/956v

Romana diversorum furtorum et ealiorum excessum.

Pro Fisco contra Beniaminum Gulielmi Minutelli; Vituccio filium Hysachini; Hysachum dello Strologo; Sabbatum alias Pattello; Angelo Gabrielis alis Taliaricetto; Cesarem bicarium Luceni; Angelus Moysis de Anguilaria; Deodatum Hysachis; Abraam Cioppagialla; Leonem Emanuelis Pazzetium; Jacobumalis Consolomonis

Die 29 ultra Februarii 1572.

Constitutus in Roma in Carceribus Curie Turris None coram Magistrum Iohannem Maria Bugnolo locumtenentem assistentemque in presentia mei notarii.

Sabbatus filius Angeli Corsetti hebreum cui delatum fuit de veritate dicente et per eum iurato tacto calamo.

Interrogatus an per paucos dies antequam ipse Corsetto escat hic carceras fuit in aliquo alio loco carceratus et qua dicta causa.

R. Credo che non fossero venti di avanti che io fosse messo prigioniero qui, che io fui messo prigioniero in corti Savella ovvero io stetti circa dieci giorni fra la pubblica et la segreta, che mi esaminava magistro Valirio, et mi domandava se io conoscevo certi che io non sapevo chi fossero, et credendo magistro Valirio che questa era una bagatella non fici rilassar con una polizza et non pagai cosa alcuna, senza il magnar et la prigion; quando poi fui uscito di prigioniero mio padre mi disse che haveva dato cinque ducati a Angelo di Anguillare, et Angelo barbaguano, perchi essi dicevano che mi havevano agiutato scappar di prigioniero. Angelo di Anguillara fu quello che mi feci la spia, et mi feci andare prigioniero; et si quelle che me ne cavi nel modo che

havevi previsto, anzi Angelo poco inanzi che io andasse prigioni mi haveva detto che cirti suoi parinti che fanno li scortica cavalli li volivano dar dieci scudi perche lui mi facessi andar pregione, et questo lo facevano perche ancora io facevo il scortica cavalli et loro non havevano voluto che io lo havesi fatto.

Interrogatus an ipse Corsetto aliquid aliud sciat de dicto Angelum de Anguillara

R. (sottolineato a latere): Se voi esaminate Iosefo Funaro et Angelo Funaro, Zampanella et Moyse Ghian troverete che questo Angelo ha fatto andar prigioni altri, chi quattro volte, et poi lui medemo li ha fatti cavari per danari che hanno dati a lui , che li ha cacciato dalle mani una gran quantità, et se dir il vero diranno bello cose di questo Angelo.

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Rome, Archivio di Stato di Roma, *Tribunale Criminale del Governatore, Investigazioni*, register 110

Witness Jacob di Massa, Jew, who was here in favour of the heirs of the deceased Rubino Rosetto. He gave his oath before me “tacto calamo”.

It was nearly eight days after the death of Rubino Rossetti, the Jew that, as chamberlain of both the community and the Company of the Death [*Gemilut Hasadim*] of the Jews in Rome, I found all the goods of this Rubino buried in his home. We inventoried these goods. We the chamberlains (Leone del Sestiero and I) went to that home because we knew that Rubino wrote a will in his own hand in favor of the Company of the Death. We (Giacob and Leone del Sestier) went with four of his relatives to his home; even our Jewish notary came with us to the home where Rubino Rossetti lived before his death. We arrived all together and Leone, my colleague, began to look amid the books in order to find something on behalf of our Company. I did the same with one of the relatives on the ground [floor], next to the fireplace; I dug two or three bricks out of ground and later, as I became tired, I told the people who carried the light to take over for me. He began to dig and, while he was still looking for, he laughed and told my colleague Leone: “The money should stay among you.” Then I was on the ground floor and Leone said: “Work here! This is the money that was walled in.” I obeyed and I told him to let me do what was needed; I took a pair of tongs and attacked the walled up money and it suddenly broke open. I told the relatives to let me manage everything and to continue holding the light. So he did. I took all the money and put it on a table. It amounted to 97 golden scudi and all the relatives claimed for them. We decided to deposit the money in the bank of Angelo di Capua; we set apart two scudi for the Company of the Death. That money was walled in close to the attic and it was easy to find that wall because it was new. This is everything that I know and on which I can say the truth.

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Die 21 agosto 1571

Jacobus di Massa hebreus tistis inductus pro parte heredum quondam Rubini Rosetti, cui delatus fuit pro iuramentum de veritate dicendi quod presenti tacto calamo

Credo che siano otto giorni in circa che essendo morto un certo Rubin Rossetti hebreo, io come camerlengo della Comunità e della Compagnia della Morte delli hebrei de Roma me trovai ad ogni cosa quando detto Rubin Rossetti sotterrato et fatto l'inventario delli suoi beni, et perche noi camerlenghi cioe Leone del Sestiero et me havemo trainteso che detto Rubin Rossetti haveva fatto non so che testamento in scrittis de man sua a favore della Compagnia della Morte andassero detto Jacob et me Camerlenghi et Leone del Sestier similmente Camerlengo et vennero anco quattro de suoi parenti con il nostro notaro hebreo in casa di detto Rubin Rossetti dove lui abitava prima che moresse et arrivati li tutti assieme detto Leone mio compagno se mise a cercare li libri se trovasse qualche cosa a favore della Compagnia et io cercavo assieme ad uno degli suoi parenti che li per terra vicino al camino se avesse possuto trovare cosa che scavai doi mattoni o tre di terra et poi essendo stanco dissi a quello che haveva il lume che io ero stanco e che cercava un poco lui, et cosi lui comencio a cercare et cercando se mese a ridere et desse a Leone mio compagno "tra voi devono stare li denari" et poi essendome io trovato da basso detto Leone disse "fatte in qua che ecco qui il denaro murato" et cosi io me feci inanzi et dissi che lasciasse fare a me et pigliai un paio de forbice et detti a quel denaro murato che subito se ruppi et dissi a quel suo parente cioe de Rubino Rossetti che lasciasse fare a me et tenesse il lume, et cosi fu fatto et io pigliai tutti li denari che erano dentro et li misi sulla banca et li contammo da doi a tre volte et trovassemo che tutti li denari che stavano in quello denaro erano novantasette scudi de oro in oro circa tutti che come ho detto erano cosi, et di poi che li havessimo conti tutti li parenti li volevano cusi pigliamo per partito che fussero depositati in un banco come furono in mano de Angelo de Capua et delli detti novantasette scudi ne dettemo doi scudi d'oro in oro per lanima sua alla Compagnia della Morte, et quel denaro stava murato in nel muro lontano dal solaro circa mezza cima, poco piu et quel muro dove stava murato detto denaro e muro novo che se vede benissimo et questo e quanto io so et ve posso dire per la verità.